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Eddie Metz Jr.

Drummer Eddie Metz Jr. has played with a lengthy list of jazz luminaries, from Steve Allen to the Count Basie Orchestra. His musicality has enabled him to support singers like Joe Williams and Sammy Davis Jr. and to co-lead a trio with bassist Nicki Parrott and pianist Rossano Sportiello. He records frequently for Arbors Records and engages in teaching future musicians at a jazz camp during the summertime.

Eddie was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on October 3, 2015 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm meeting with Eddie Metz Jr. today, a short twelve hours after an awesome gig last night at Hamilton — 9 A.M. for a jazz musician.

EM: Yeah. That's okay. I don't do most of the things I used to do, that kept me from waking up in the morning. I get older and wiser I guess.

MR: Yeah. Our bedtime moves up.

EM: That's right, yeah.

MR: I just was very impressed by watching the three of you — Rossano and Nicki and yourself, with dynamics last night. How and when did you learn the importance of that?

EM: Oh very early. My dad was a piano player in a Dixieland/swing style. He loved ragtime but he couldn't quite get the stride thing going. So it was just very great. And he wrote songs, he wrote hundreds of songs and arrangements. And so I grew up listening to music, okay, that had dynamics and had melodies and rhythm, sometimes, for his style, not so complex rhythms as I got into the drums and my rhythm expanded, to be able to do over the bar line and stuff. But until the day he died he could look at me and say, "stop screwing around and just play time." You know? And so from my dad came my concept of the time and what the drummer did with the time. You know, music has — the definition of music has certain elements, you know, melody, harmony, timbre, rhythm, and I think dynamics kind of gets held out of that. And it's a hugely important part, and it has been since, you know, classical music. You listen to a Beethoven symphony and you know it's this grand thing and all of a sudden it's down to a flute solo again.

MR: Right.

EM: So the dynamics is a huge part. And with Rossano on piano, he's such a dynamic player. And his touch, even when he's playing light, is really very accurate. I don't know if you noticed it.

MR: I did.

the intensity of the beat continues. And that's a really difficult thing to do in music. I think it's the hardest thing to do in music. I used to hear that with Oscar Peterson records, trio records with Ray Brown and Ed Thigpen. They'd be playing and all of a sudden the bottom would drop out and Oscar might be just playing one note. But the beat continued through. And that's what really impressed me.

MR: I love how — I know I physically will lean forward when that happens.

EM: Oh, to listen.

MR: Because I'm listening so much harder, and all of a sudden it's a great effect.

EM: It makes people listen. And sometimes we'll start a concert with Rossano. This trio has kind of evolved into the Rossano Sportiello Trio. You know Nicki will front it, or sometimes I will front it, it's kind of Rossano's band. It started as my idea, presenting it to Arbors — oh I'd love to record with Nicki and Rossano. And Mat Domber went, "okay, when?" And, "it's your record." And that was okay. So I did that "Bridging the Gap" record.

MR: I have it here. And I thought it was so cool like you've got a Steely Dan song on there.

EM: Stevie Wonder.

MR: Yeah.

EM: Yeah, but see when I was growing up, in the 60s and 70s, and probably you too, I had all this jazz coming at me and I was playing gigs starting at age 14, playing dance gigs on the weekend. And it was mostly jazz. We played three rock songs.

MR: Define what kind of jazz it was.

EM: Oh it'd be standards. "Take the A Train."

MR: I'm going to pause for a second and turn off the heater.

EM: It's probably over here.

MR: Yeah I got it.

EM: You can splice this I'm sure.

MR: I did the same thing yesterday.

MR: Yeah so that was what kind of jazz?

EM: Well it was what we call club dates. Standards for dancing at a country club in Ann Arbor, Michigan. So we played bossa novas, we played rumbas, we played cha-chas, we played straight ahead jazz songs, Duke Ellington ballads. Nothing too fast, nothing too slow. It was businessman's bounce. You know, and ballads were like [scats and snaps fingers]. That was about as slow as it got. And then the faster tune [scats and snaps fingers]. It was for dancing. Nothing too fast. Nothing too slow. So that's where I really cut my teeth. I also was playing Dixieland gigs at a local pizza place. So I was getting that. But then on the radio I listened to all this rock & roll. It was the Rolling Stones and

the Beatles and, you know, whoever else was popular in the 60s and 70s and I love that music also. In fact I just did a rock & roll record last year.

MR: Oh neat.

EM: It's a remake of "Ride Captain Ride."

MR: Oh that's a great song.

EM: Yeah, Blues Image is one surviving member, Mike Pinera, who wrote that song. So I did this whole new rock & roll record with them. He also was part of Iron Butterfly when they did "In-A-Gadda-Da-Vida."

MR: No kidding.

EM: Yeah. So this is the official remake. But that's another part of my career.

MR: Right. Well, versatility.

EM: But we're talking about jazz here, so growing up playing standards, learning those songs.

MR: Do you remember the first time you got paid to play?

EM: Yeah.

MR: What did you make?

EM: I made $36.

MR: That's quite a lot.

EM: Yeah. That was in about 1971, '70. I was in seventh grade.

MR: For my first gig I made $4.

EM: $4? Yeah. And this was actually on a TV show with the local pizza parlor Dixieland band. And so it went through the union too. I had to become a union member, so it had taxes taken out of it and everything.

MR: You were the real thing.

EM: I felt like, hey, I was in seventh grade. What did I know? $36, that went towards me new pair of hi-hats that cost $100.

MR: Speaking of hi-hats, we're going to veer off here, but there was a couple of moments last night where you literally were just playing your hi-hat and the snare and almost pretending to play the bass drum. And the power in that, I'm just sort of mystified by it sometimes. It's hard to teach I think.

EM: I know. When it comes down to the time of the music, that's the pulse, and that's the quarter note. A quarter note gets a beat for those of you who are watching this who don't know anything about music. A quarter note is the beat [taps steadily]. There's the beat right there. And those are quarter notes. One, two, three, four. So when you can master just playing quarter notes at a steady tempo and not waver no matter what's going on around you, then I think you've really stumbled onto something. Maybe not stumble, that's what your goal was. Now the famous drummer Peter Erskine, who is unbelievable,

stuff at the very beginning for about a minute. And then he stops and he goes like this. The quarter note's on the hi-hat and that's it. No opening and closing, just quarter notes. And he looks at the camera and he goes, "if you can't do this for three minutes without wavering, then all the other stuff is just a bad imitation of good drummers." And I thought that was beautiful. That was right up my alley. I've never met Peter. I've always loved everything he did. I saw him at Carnegie Hall in 1976 with Maynard. Phil Woods opened that concert and they wouldn't let him off the stage. It was with Harry Leahey and [Mike] Melillo and Bill Goodwin and all of that. Great quintet.

MR: The "Showboat" group.

EM: Oh my God it was — and they didn't want to let them off the stage. In fact Maynard's band was sitting on the stage watching them. And they looked at Maynard and Maynard went, "go ahead, play another one, I don't care." And it was just killer. And so Peter was with Maynard at that time. So it was more rock & roll Maynard Ferguson. And so to see him go and play straight ahead jazz, I did hear him when he was very young with Kenton when he was 19 years old or something. Just a powerhouse of a player. But now he can do all of this delicate stuff. And it's just again, intensity of the beat when you're playing soft and doing that. And I picked that up from, I saw Gus Johnson one time. We were watching them on that video. It went to piano solo and he went just to hi-hat, closed hi-hat, and nothing else. And it still was swinging. And I was like it can be done, yes it can be done. You don't have to play all that extra stuff. When it comes down to the quarter note just play it. Now the subdivision might be different. A drummer like Connie Kay from the Modern Jazz Quartet played his jazz being very even eighths. Did you ever notice that? Okay. Or if you got to somebody like Jake Hanna or Buddy Rich or Max Roach or any of the bebop drummers, their beat kind of went [claps]. So there was that in-between that mystified me most of the time. It was like well Connie Kay can get away with it playing straight eighths in a jazz sense, and these other guys can do it with a triplet feel, which is the jazz-swing trio — the first and third note of a triplet — right? [scats] The shuffle feel without the middle note. The ride cymbal pattern for drummers, that's where that comes from [claps]. So if you're subdividing [claps]. Now it's hokey when you go [claps]. But when you have it in the ride beat and it's constant and it's steady, I think it helps everyone just not worry about where the beat is. And then they can play the bass or the piano. How do they do it. I have no idea how they do it. I mean Rossano, all the notes and everything. I'm just hitting things with pieces of wood, you know? He's over there actually — but I have to give the support. So it all comes back to the quarter note again.

MR: Right. What's the role of ego in this — what you're talking about — if you have to be happy, and Peter Erskine is saying, you better be able to do this and nothing else for a while.

EM: If you're called upon to do that. Now sometimes some guys would never think of doing that, maybe because they can't do that, or it's just so simple a concept that — you know, less is more right now, for me.

MR: You have to like space I think. There's some drummers that I play with on occasion who just feel any space that comes up that's mine.

EM: Fill it in. Yeah. You mentioned the ego. With this trio there's no ego. If somebody throws out an idea we usually all jump on it. A rhythmic thing for me or Rossano will play something. If you noticed when we were playing all of a sudden Rossano will play something or Nicki and we'll all just smile, all at the same time. Whether it's a funny quote or a rhythmic thing or some funny melody line. And so we really listen to each other intently when we're playing. And that's another big thing about music. You have to be able to have the proficiency on your instrument to just be playing while you're listening to everything else that's going on. You talk about musicians listening to each other while they're playing. The bigger the band the harder it is to maybe zero in on one instrument. With a trio it's just the piano, bass and drums and the balance that goes out to the audience. Before it even reaches the PA system. Like we played acoustic last night. My problem would have been playing too loud for the piano that's not miced. I don't think there was any balance problems last night, but again, back to playing as soft as you possibly can with the intensity of the beat I think is the hardest thing to do in music.

MR: You had a path, like you were going to go into business or something?

EM: Oh yeah. I graduated high school in Ann Arbor, Michigan in 1976 and was accepted at Berklee College of Music in Boston, and placed in the number three big band as a freshman. That was like what? Okay. I guess I'm pretty good at what I'm doing here, and I'd love to go to Berklee and be a musician. And my dad was a musician, never a full time musician. He was an investment banker and kept the food on the table. He could have been a professional musician had he gone that way but he decided not to. He was raised a different way. And so when I decided to go into music he was like, "I don't think so" — even with an acceptance to Berklee with a full ride. And I didn't go. I'm not going to say it's a regret, but I wonder where my career might have gone if I'd gone in that direction. So that was 1976. Instead I stayed in Ann Arbor. I didn't go to the University of Michigan, I went to Eastern Michigan, five miles down the road, in Ypsilanti, Michigan. And I was in business school. I was a marketing major for three years. So the first year was easy, you get algebra 101 and psychology 101 and English 101. When you

write a letter in the proper business form with the headings and all of that stuff, and memos, and all of that stuff you need to do when you're in business. And I started going like I don't know if this is for me. And then in the meantime I'm still in my hometown playing gigs Friday and Saturday nights. Now I didn't hang out with the guys in the dorms, I went and played gigs. I was making 75 bucks a night as a college student. You know 150 bucks a week. I bought pizza for everybody. Because I was in the dorms. And so I was in college just partying out and having a good old time, playing my gigs and being in the marching band and being in the concert band and being in the jazz band at Eastern Michigan, and eventually I just stopped going to my academic classes. I went to the music classes. And I became a huge pothead. It was the 70s, it was the thing to do.

MR: You're diving into the whole thing.

EM: Yeah. You know, drinking and smoking pot and girls and all that stuff, and I was just happy going to band and playing gigs along the way. And I said hey, this isn't terrible. Forget those classes. So eventually technically I flunked out of Eastern Michigan. So I laid off a semester and went back on my own dime, I went and found a day job, along with doing the other gigs, and got my own apartment, and went back as a music major, a music education major, taking clarinet and theory and all that stuff. And I got a 4.0. Back then a 4.0 was the highest you could get. I had straight A's right down the board. And I mailed my report card to my dad. And I said, "dad, I'm thinking of coming to William Paterson College in New Jersey. They have a jazz program there and I really want to be a professional musician." He was like, "okay. You've proved it to me that you really want to do this." So I moved to New Jersey where my parents had lived. They moved there in the middle of my senior year in high school but I had stayed out there. Another traumatic story but that's okay. And I'm over it. And went to Eastern as a music major, moved back to New Jersey and went to William Paterson college in Wayne, New Jersey, entered the jazz studies in performance and they accepted me. And I transferred enough academics that I had taken at Eastern and actually passed to transfer in to only take music classes when I went to William Paterson. That was great. That started in 1980. Two years later I was trying to — a friend of mine was playing with Grover Mitchell. He was playing trombone in the Basie band. He had a band that was playing at the Red Parrot in New York City and the Rainbow Room, back and forth, when the Basie band wasn't on the road. And it was all the Basie guys. So a friend of mine was John Melito, a trumpet player, he'd been in Clark Terry's last big band. He said, "Eddie, put a cassette together." A cassette. "We're having drummer problems. The drummer is terrible." He said, "just get me a cassette as soon as you can." So I put it together that night and got it to him. He took it to the gig and gave it to Grover. I didn't think anything of it, thinking maybe the

would get that job and stay in school and just do that. And about three months after I did that I got a phone call. It was Labor Day 1982 and it was Count Basie calling me personally.

MR: He called you personally?

EM: Yeah. I had all my information on the cassette. And what had happened was Grover was listening to it on the bus and he said, "hey Basie, here, listen to this." Because Greg Fields was getting ready to leave. Maybe we could check this guy out. I had big band stuff on there. And he said yeah sure. So Basie called me personally. I said, "who is this?" Who's messing with me, you know? And then I recognized his voice it was like oh my gosh.

MR: Did he call himself Count? Do you recall?

EM: I think he called himself Bill.

MR: Bill Basie.

EM: Yeah the guys called him a various assortment of names. Bill, Chief. I called him Chief. Some guys called him Count. Other guys called him Boss. It didn't matter, he was just so well respected. He was a great guy. So I get the call from Count Basie. So he said, "Sonny Cohn, the manager, will be calling you shortly and he'll let you know all the details." He said, "we want you to join the band starting October 8." And that was Labor Day. So that's like six weeks. I was registered for school, all ready to go back to school. And actually I had just finished — it was amazing — my girlfriend at the time, who became my first wife and the mother of my children — we were sitting there watching the "Jerry Lewis Telathon." And they just had Sammy Davis from Harrah's in Lake Tahoe. I'm like oh man, wouldn't it be great to get a gig like that. I swear five minutes later the phone rang and it was Basie on the phone. It was unbelievable. Two months after I joined the band we were sitting on the same stage at Harrah's in Lake Tahoe with Sammy Davis. And every night I got to play three songs with Sammy, the Basie band would do about a half an hour warm-up. And then Sammy would come out and we'd do three songs. The first one was "My Shining Hour" I'll never forget it. It was fast as hell and a lot of drum stuff in it. And I actually had Sammy Davis come up and say, "great job." I remember Basie just looking up and smiling at me, because everything seems okay with the band. Freddie Green was kind of a grumbly old man but he didn't ever say anything. Actually I used to get this from Freddie Green. See this arm moving, and then I'd see his arm stop and I knew what was coming he'd go like this. So as a young guy, 24 years old, Freddie Green started out kind of shaking his head and looking at you, I thought what am I doing wrong I thought it felt great. And then Cleveland Eaton the bass player would lean over and go, "don't worry about him." I'm like what, don't worry

what have I gotten myself into. After the first song we played the first night, I'll never forget, Toledo, Ohio, Masonic Auditorium, 2000 people in the audience. And we played "Wind Machine" the first song. It was always the first opener. Sammy Nestico's. Like a bat out of hell. And when we got to the end of that, the very first song I played with the band was "Wind Machine." I was shaking so badly physically. I was behind the drums going I can't believe this is it. Of course the next tune was a blues, and Basie starts out [scats and snaps fingers]. My hand was shaking so bad I couldn't play those quarter notes I was talking about. Because you know, closed hi-hat. And hi-hat stand clicking. I couldn't do it because my hand was going like this. And Cleve's going, "settle down, relax." I go, "I'm trying, I'm trying." Eventually I kind of settled in. But you know, 24 years old and no rehearsal. My rehearsal was in the dressing room with Basie saying, "Is there anything I should know here? I'm only 24 years old why did I get this gig." He says, "oh just kick 'em in the ass. They haven't had that in a while."

MR: That's why he wanted you.

EM: Okay. I guess he felt my energy. And I wasn't the most technical, and I never have been really the most technical drummer like a Buddy Rich or Butch Miles, who was my teacher when I was growing up for a year. He was my first drum teacher. It was great. He taught me all kinds of stuff. He goes, "you've got the time, I just have to teach you the tricks now." The tricks of the trade. So he did. He showed me all kinds of stuff. And technique, we worked on technique of course.

MR: I love your Freddie Green story because I have a story from a bass player, Jimmy Lewis, who was with the small group in the early 50s.

EM: Oh yeah, like the Kansas City Five.

MR: And he basically told the same thing. He says Freddie, he says, if the time starts to get away he would just look at you.

EM: Yeah. He didn't tolerate it. And yet I heard on Basie records with Sonny Payne near the end of his career with the band, he and Freddie were fighting all the time. You can hear it a couple of times on "Sinatra Live at the Sands." There's a couple of times. The set that the Basie band played before Frank Sinatra came out. The dinner set. So you can hear all the silverware clanking and a guy yelling, "waiter." And maybe the mob guys sitting down front because, you know, Frank was there. "Hey bring me my food" you know. You can hear all that but the Basie band, they are just smoking. But there's times when Sonny Payne and Freddie were just rubbing each other.

MR: Was Sonny like on the forward side of the beat?

EM: It's kind of hard to explain. I think at the time — I shouldn't say anything that's really not true — but I think Sonny was drinking a lot at the time. And he knew he was kind of

such a showman and always stole the spotlight from whoever was up there. You know, throwing sticks around and doing all that. He's one of my heroes, but I did hear those things, stories about him that was kind of like — talking about ego. You know? It probably got in the way there. So when I was on the band I was just trying to be — you know I was one of four white guys. There never was any racial indication from anyone on the band. From the top to the bottom. Nothing about black and white. No racial stuff, which was relaxing. Because those guys had gone through all that racial stuff. You know, staying in separate hotels and — one of the famous black bands and, "yeah you can come in and play the theater but you've got to leave out the back door and go to the other side of town and stay at the black hotel. You know, they'd been through all that. There was no —

MR: Did they talk about it?

EM: No. There was no racial fighting at all. Four white guys. I was one of them. Eric Schneider was a tenor player from Chicago, Dale Carley was playing lead trumpet at the time, he's from Silver Springs, Maryland, and Bob Summers was another trumpet player. We were the four white guys. There was never a black and white issue on the band, which made it so relaxed you know. Because there could have been very easily. You never know. Guys like Miles, he didn't hide his racial preference. He told everybody, you know, crazy white men.

MR: When you first got on the Basie bus, was there a question like where do I go?

EM: No. They said, "new boy, in the back." That's what they said. Sonny Cohn, "your seat's in the back right in front of the toilet." Okay. "Yes sir. No problem." And then across the aisle was Cleveland Eaton because he'd take the bass and lay it on the back seat and then strap it in. So there was the big long back seat in the bus and the toilet. Cleveland was that seat and I was the one across from him. And in front of me was Danny Turner and Bob Summers and all the way down to the front seat where Basie was. And there was a lot of really cool stuff. And at the time we didn't take any bus trips longer than three or four hours. We flew everywhere, which is a real luxury, because like the Glenn Miller band, they still live on the bus — 48 weeks a year on the bus. Of course to get to Europe you've got to fly and things like that. But one nighters on the bus. They had Greyhound buses meet us at the airport, take us to the hotel, take us to the gig, back to the airport. We did the longest bus trip I think was three hours.

MR: Did you have to play a different set of drums every night?

EM: No I had my drums with me.

MR: That went on the plane?

EM: Hard cases. Yeah. This was all pre 9/11 of course. It was 1982. Hard cases for the drums.

much equipment and pull out a Ben Franklin, "who wants to help us?" And the skycaps ran. At the airport they'd see Sonny get off the bus and they'd all run towards him, to make the big tip. Because you could push luggage through then. There wasn't extra luggage charges. Now Jeff Hamilton, he travels with his drums. It's in his contract that they have to pay all the overage charges and everything. He's got six extra cases, all under 50 pounds.

MR: I remember that when we started doing these interviews. We had nine road cases of stuff. The stuff was big.

EM: Yeah the Basie band had those road cases. All the music — there was three music cases. There was a great big huge box that had mutes in it, all the big huge trombone mutes. And there were stand cases. They had the old band front stands, metal ones, that were heavy, the drums, the bass amp had a road case. So it was like 12 or 13 pieces of equipment and then everybody had a suitcase and a carryon. So thank God it was pre-9/11.

MR: Basie was in his declining years?

EM: Yeah. He was in a wheelchair. I think he'd had a stroke in about 1979 — 78 or 79. Butch was on the band at the time. And that was when I really became a fan of the band. When my teacher got the gig with the Basie band it was like whoa. So then I immersed myself in the Basie things. I bought all the old records like "April in Paris" and "Standing Ovation," "Live at Birdland," all of that stuff. "Atomic Basie." And I just studied it and studied it. I had 95% of the book memorized when I got there.

MR: Where did Duffy Jackson fit in that timeline?

EM: There were four white drummers in a row. From Butch, who got the gig I think in '75 through about '79, then Duffy for a year, then Greg Fields was there for two years and then I was there for six months, and then Dennis Mackrel was after me. In 1983 he came after me. So I'm just honored to have my name in the list of people. It doesn't matter that I didn't record with them or that I didn't do any extensive touring. It was all domestic. I just missed a tour to England, I just missed a tour to Japan. It was like I don't care. Just to sit from the drums and to look down from where the drums were and look down and see Count Basie at the piano was unbelievable, and I'll never forget it. As a 24-year-old guy. That was 32 years ago now. I'm 57 now. Yeah. So it's pretty amazing. So to play with guys like Bucky and the guys that I've had a chance to record with over my career, Bob Haggart, the bass player Bob Haggart, Kenny Davern, Bob Wilber, Dave Frishberg, jazz guys like that. Just working with Bucky and seeing him this morning and having him say, "come here, give me a hug, I love you man." That makes it all worthwhile. I'm going to cry now.

MR: Yeah, yeah. I know exactly what you mean. They seem to have — maybe it's just the lives they've led.

EM: Oh yeah.

MR: Maria Schneider said something about that. She said, "you have to live a life if you want to" — you can't just play music you have to —

EM: You have to live it. That's right. And that's true for any music. Look at the rock & rollers. They live it. Why don't the jazzers? Well they did. For a long time. I think back, I was heavily influenced by the 52nd Street Eddie Condon's and Jimmy Ryan's and that whole scene there in the 50s. Hugely influenced. I just bought all the records I could. My dad had a lot in his collection too. He wasn't so much of a big band guy, I started the big band collection. Dad had Ray Charles records and Oscar Peterson Trio and Sergio Mendes. That was how I practiced my bossa novas. Sergio Mendes and Brazil '66. And I still listen to it 'til this day. But then the rock thing for me too, I practiced and practiced and practiced to the band Chicago. I loved that band Chicago. And Danny Seraphine, the original drummer. I've recently gotten in touch with him. I teach at a band camp two weeks out of the year near Sacramento. It's a traditional jazz camp. We don't read any music other than lead sheets. So it's all improvised. And the teachers will play and say, here's the role of the clarinet, here's the role of the tenor, here's the role of the trumpet. And try and teach the kids how to play music totally improvising. Like jazz groups do. Pick a tune and play. So we're there. And I had a student who has become my number one fan. He has a show in California called "Percussion Discussion." And it's an NPR show. It's just in California now. And he interviews all kinds of drummers. So Danny Seraphine, the original drummer from Chicago, who disappeared for a long time, I never knew where he went. He had a falling out with the band and just took his money and went. He has now reappeared on the scene and wrote a book about his experience with Chicago and growing up as a tough kid in Chicago. And Jim got an autographed copy of that book to me. And I was like wow. Because I had told him Danny Seraphine was a huge influence on me on the rock thing. Playing with rock bands, like with horns. Chicago; Blood, Sweat & Tears; Earth, Wind & Fire; the Tower of Power; all the funk bands. All the rock bands. But Chicago was my most favorite. Their first record.

MR: Their first record, yeah.

EM: I used to put that record on and run down the stairs to the basement to try to hit the first note. In the time that you would drop a needle. Drop a needle and down the stairs and try and hit the first note.

MR: Because your stereo was upstairs.

EM: Dad's stereo was upstairs. So I'd put on a stack of records on the long spindle.

conditioning and heating ducts downstairs so I had a little stage for my drums. This is the man that didn't want me to be a professional drummer. He did all that for me. A finished basement and heat down there in the winter time. And speakers right here for me. It was kind of pre-headphones and pre iPod and all of that stuff. We practiced to LPs. I put on the stack of records and the first one always was Chicago Transit Authority.

MR: Which side?

EM: First side. Very first song. "Introduction" and then "Does Anybody Really Know What Time It Is" and then "Beginnings." And then usually I'd go up and take the whole stack off and then flip it over. And it was question 67, 68. And listen. All those records. I loved them. And to this day I can still play them note for note. That's how much I practiced. So I sent a note, I wrote an email to Danny telling him what an influence he is. And he says, "the next time you're out near San Francisco give me a call and we'll get together and have lunch." Because I guess Jim played him a couple of things that I'm on. So those kind of things, as I'm getting older I'm appreciating those things more and more, to meet my heroes in my career. To have been able to record a record with what essentially was Soprano Summit. Davern, Wilber, Haggart on bass, Dave Frishberg on piano and Bucky, and me on drums. It was an Arbors record called "Reunion at Arbors." And it's Soprano Summit. I grew up listening and playing along to those records. Rosengarden. And Bucky was on those records and Milt Hinton. I got to play with Milt. I got to play with George Duvivier. I got to play with all those people we saw at least one time. George Duvivier I played two sets with him. Unbelievable.

MR: I'm jealous. It's great.

EM: It is. And I don't want to spout it or anything but all these guys were part of musical history, for jazz history, which I don't know, is kind of — it seems to be not ignored, but not as many people know about that part of jazz as when Miles and Coltrane were coming through at the same time. Everybody's attention kind of went that way.

MR: Yeah. As if that's where things really started.

EM: Right. Well if you go back before then it was the Dixieland guys and it was Louis Armstrong. And all those guys I worked with. We'd talk about music and different things and invariably someone would say Louis was the guy. He made it possible for everyone else. If Bix hadn't died, where would his career have gone? How influential would he have been to maybe hear him on a more modern recording than some of that old stuff — which is wonderful stuff with Frankie Trumbauer and Chauncey Morehouse on drums. But it was old style recording.

MR: Right. It's kind of a shame because people listen to it and because of the sound of it it's easy to sort of dismiss.

EM: Right. And I think the younger guys have a problem with it because it's so diatonic. When you're playing Dixieland there's not too many sharp nines or flat nines or flat fives. You know Eddie Condon used to say, "those modern guys, they flat their fifths. We drink our fifths." You know that was a famous Eddie Condon quote. But I think that part of history, the improvised six or seven piece band, like at the jazz parties, watching that video last night. That was great. I loved seeing that. And I'd love to get a copy of that sometime. It's being forgotten about.

MR: To me, I've got this idea that most of it is too happy to be taken seriously as an art form.

EM: Yeah. It is a happy music.

MR: And for some reason the scholars and so forth, it doesn't have enough I don't know, trauma to it or something.

EM: Well and some players think it's too constraining harmonically. But I played with Wild Bill Davison several times. Oh my God, it was unbelievable. His energy and the way he would lead the band through an out chorus, it was outrageous. Pee Wee Erwin was the same way. Warren Vache can do it. And that's the bag he was coming out of. Warren grew up listening to Bobby Hackett. Nobody remembers who Bobby Hackett was anymore. Oh my gosh.

MR: Well someone does. Rossano yesterday says —

EM: Yeah right. And luckily I've been able to play with people who — my dad got to play with Hackett one time and they actually did a little recording. It came out years later. It's like he would start every song by clicking his ring on the bell for the tempo. So the band could hear it over the crowd talking. This little kind of clinking sound. Everybody knew where the tempo was. And Ernie Hackett was playing drums on there. I did go one night to see that. That was at the Ponchartrain in Detroit.

MR: Well you've got all these great gigs you've played. And this is a sort of a hard question. Do you recall your worst gig ever?

EM: Boy oh boy. There could be a whole bunch of them. A couple of gigs I learned my lesson early to not overindulge. Especially drinking. I don't drink anymore and I never had a problem with it, I just don't care for it anymore the way it makes you feel. A couple of times with the rock band getting a little too drunk to play and they were my good buddies, we'd played together for a long time. The piano player, Tom Hook, he's looking at me. I'm going "I'm sorry." He's like, "hey get out of here." And he finished the night by himself on piano playing Tom Waits songs and things like that. But yeah, things like that. Gigs where we were always too loud. "Turn that P.A. off." "Well we don't have a P.A., we're a jazz group, we're just playing for dancing." "You guys are too loud. Turn that P.A. down." "We don't have a P.A." There's a microphone so they can do speeches

time. People see the drums coming in and they do not sit near the bandstand and they don't understand that I could probably play drums quieter than anybody. You know? So worst gigs would have been more like dealing with food and beverage managers instead of the other musicians.

MR: You spent quite a few years at Disney World?

EM: I did.

MR: And I think I read in some of your bio information that they eventually cut back on their music?

EM: I went to Florida in 1985. I'd gotten married and had a kid. P.J. was born in October of '84. Sorry October of '85. And we were living in Flemington, New Jersey at the time. And I was working in Allentown with a guy named Parke Frankenfield who was big in the Lehigh Valley area. Again, a band organizer who had a big band, a small group, and a steady Friday and Saturday with this quartet. And he played keyboards at the time, although he was mostly a trombone player. A jack of all trades. He played everything. And I was also working in the summer at Great Adventure amusement park in Jackson, New Jersey. So Flemington was half way between the two. So newly married, with a new kid, Great Adventure was closing for the season and Parke Frankenfield was moving to Vero Beach, Florida. And all my work was gone. I was doing Monday nights with Woody Allen at the old Michael's Pub on 53rd street for $50 on Monday nights. And that was the extent of my gigs. I had a wife and a kid. So I had gone to the Sacramento festival with Parke Frankenfield, the Sacramento Jubilee, which at the time was the largest jazz festival, about 120 bands and 50 stages. It was my first jazz festival I've gone to. I was like this is amazing. And I met some guys from Orlando who were there with the Rosie O'Grady's band. Bill Allred being one of them, the trombone player. And especially Davey Jones became a quick friend of mine. I met them. He said, "where are you from and why don't you move to Orlando?" And I went well okay. He goes, "come down, stay at my house, I'll take you all over and introduce you to everybody." It was a huge music scene. Not a jazz scene, just making your living in the trenches in the music business. Conventions, and theme parks were there. Universal wasn't there but Disney was there. And at the time Disney had 400 full time musicians. Salary and benefits. No hourly wage and benefits. And I went down and tried out for Disney and stayed at Davey's house and tried out for Disney. And they were like, "okay move down here and we'll status you." You know, because it is a corporation, a large corporation. You've got to go through all the initiation, not initiation but orientation and get your I.D. cards and get on the books and all that stuff. I went down there and moved down there with my wife of a year and a half and my son who was three months old, in December of 1985.

had worked around town and played at Rosie O'Grady's and started doing conventions, got to know the contractors in town. Disney had 400 full time musicians there at the time, and now, 30 years later, they're down to 65 I think, full time musicians. They've just cut a lot of the entertainment. As I understand it, just as I moved to town, Operations, Disney World Operations had taken over entertainment, and they knew nothing about entertainment. They are wondering why are all these people sitting around in between shows? They just did a 20 minute show, soaking wet from the heat and the humidity. It feels like 130° outside, and they're wondering why we aren't doing something in between shows.

MR: The bean counters.

EM: Yeah. The bean counters. This is wasted time. Make them fold shirts or something. And they did. They had a couple of managers do that. So I survived Disney for 15 years doing all kinds of different jobs and also working on the outside. And my last few years there was when I really started doing jazz parties and festivals, either as a solo, just a drummer that they invite to the jazz party, or I was working with a band called the Black Dogs which is a great, great Dixieland band. Best band I ever worked with. It was unbelievable. Kind of obscure, and nobody really knew about it other than the people in California at the festivals we played. And we had people lined up around the block. We sold 1,200 cassettes in three days there one time. Playing three sets a day. We couldn't hand them out fast enough. It was amazing. So that was a hugely powerful band, and then the band leader stole all the money and then disbanded. But, you know, there's all kinds of stories like that in the music business. Somebody gets greedy. And it really could've gone on, because it was so different, it could have gone on to be like a warm-up act for major rock bands, because it was so different. Like Steely Dan — love Steely Dan — I love that band — you never know who's going to play warm-up for them. Last time I saw them they had an organ trio from Chicago. And they were just great. Guys you never even heard of. Because Donald Fagan heard them playing in a bar somewhere in Chicago. And their drummer, Keith Carlock, you know, he's huge now. He heard him playing in a bar in New York. Because they actually went to see the guitar player.

MR: I see.

EM: And he was playing drums with them. He was just a country boy from Mississippi. James Taylor, Steely Dan, Eric Clapton, he's doing all these gigs. He's like Steve Gadd's sub. What a position that is to be in. And maybe if I'd stuck around New York I could have done more stuff like that or I could be on Broadway. A lot of my friends, John Allred, the greatest trombone player I know, is in New York playing on Broadway, sitting in the pit. Making good money. Making good pension. Not having to be on the road. That's a

blessing these days, not having to deal with airports and airlines and stuff. I'm not sick of it yet.

MR: Well speaking of being on the road I know you have to be on the road soon. I just wanted to play — let's see what was I going to play here? I was going to play here? I was going to play —

EM: Oh, that's "Bridging the Gap"

MR: Yeah.

EM: Oh, the Basie. That's completely improvised. We just said roll the tape and we followed Rossano. Completely improvised.

MR: And the title, the "NER Blues"?

EM: Nicki, Eddie, Rossano.

MR: Okay.

EM: And so that was my concept of — well we'll let it play. That's that dynamic thing you were talking about. And nobody does that better than Rossano.

MR: I told him yesterday, oh I know what it was, one of the recordings was "St. Louis Blues" you had done.

EM: Oh yeah, that's on a live record.

MR: Yeah. And there's one point where he sounds like he's the horn section of the Basie band. He's playing [scats].

EM: He's amazing. He's totally amazing. He has the technical prowess to play anything that comes to his mind. But he's heavily influenced by the older guys: Willie "The Lion," Basie, Jelly Roll Morton, as players. Fats Waller as a player. You know Basie, everybody thinks of him as just kind of going plink-plink-plink-plink. He was the most feared guy on 52nd Street in his day. He could really play. Listen to "The Kid From Red Bank." It's unbelievable. He's playing stride. He studied with Fats Waller. So he knew how to do it. He just figured out I don't have to kill myself I've got this whole band here. I'll just fill in the little holes. You know? That became his trademark. So he never broke a sweat again, which is kind of nice. Saves your clothes on the road. That was my dilemma when I was on the road, I was a young guy and had never really been on the road and playing with a big band, sweating profusely every night, to keep clothes fresh. This is a great story. So at one point we're in California in San Francisco and Harold Jones, the drummer, shows up. He was with I think Natalie Cole at the time and they were on break. So he came to see the band, it was all his old buddies. Because Harold was on the "Live at Birdland" record and the "Standing Ovation" record I think also. Great Basie drummer. He said, "you want to know something?" "What?" He said, "Papa Jo Jones told me 'wear tee shirts underneath your dress shirt.'" He goes, "the tee shirts, you can buy them anywhere and if

— you can get three or four nights out of a dress shirt if you wear a tee shirt." And he says," and don't wear that shirt on the bus to the gig. Only change at the gig." He goes, "because nobody can smell you from the audience. And it doesn't matter that the other guys could smell your nasty shirt, you're getting four days out of a dress shirt." Survival on the road. And to this day I wear tee shirts. Guys say, "how do you wear those, they're so constraining." I say, "because I can get four nights out of a dress shirt. How many nights do you get out of a dress shirt when you don't wear a tee shirt?" "One." "Okay. There you go." So things like that. Warren Vache told me how to fold a suit, that he had learned. I think Benny Golson or somebody taught him that, or maybe Clark. You can fold up a suit inside out and not have any wrinkles. So you didn't see guys with big suitcases back them, you saw them with a little suitcase. Now of course a lot of guys wore coat and tie when they traveled back then anyway. Bucky still does, and John Pizzarelli. Every picture I see on FaceBook of John Pizzarelli he's wearing a suit.

MR: Yeah. Joe Wilder and all those guys.

EM: Yeah. They put a suit on every day. But to fold up a suit jacket with no wrinkles in a little carry on bag. Nice.

MR: And you actually answered the question, I didn't even get to — I was going to say do you have any advice for up and coming musicians?

EM: Wear a tee shirt.

MR: Wear a tee shirt.

EM: And listen. Listen to everybody that's around you. Take that little mixing board in your head. If you look at a mixing board and you know what it's like. There's usually a solo button or a mute button for each channel. So think of each instrument as having its own little channel. You want to hear more trumpet? Press that solo button in your head and the trumpet comes right to you. You want to hear more bass? Hit that. So that's how I try to explain it to kids, about listening. The listening was so ingrained into me, about listening to what's going on. Because drums are a support instrument. We get our chance to play our solos but we're in a support role. Drums and bass. We're supporting everybody else. And our job is to make them sound as good as possible. Because I don't want to be standing out there playing a horn. I like to hide in my cage behind the drums you know. Standing out front, I've gotten better about it, about playing solos and stuff, but I'd rather try and make somebody sound good in a support role, that's part of a team effort. If you think of it as a sports team, everybody knows their role, and you just go out and play your role and keep your ears open and to be able to respond instantly to anything that might come up, rhythmically, harmonically, whatever it is, change of style, change of feel. I like to pride myself — I can play just about any style that's thrown my way from rock to funk

to R&B to Latin to Gospel, to whatever. So I immerse myself into the music. I'd love to have a Steely Dan gig. Please.

MR: Me too. You like all the same stuff I do.

EM: Yeah, I love it. You know and so that "Bridging the Gap" record had a rock influence — more pop, not rock but pop influence. Stevie Wonder "Overjoyed" was just one of my favorite songs and Rossano tackled it and did a great job on it.

MR: Well on that note.

EM: Then we did a Fifth Dimension song. "One Less Bell [to Answer]" I said Nicki, can you sing this?" She said, "it's funny, my teacher just mentioned this song to me." I said, "great." She says, "okay, we'll do it." And there it is.

MR: Well you have big ears. Not literally, but you know what I mean.

EM: Yeah. I think it's really important, especially for rhythm section guys. You know you're playing in a trumpet section or an orchestra you have to listen to what's going on. You have to listen to your section leader. You've got to match their pitch, whether it's right or wrong. You've got to match their pitch. You've got to follow the conductor. It's pretty simple when you think about it. Some guys make it too complicated.

MR: Well thanks for your time today and last night.

EM: Thank you Monk. It was great. Anytime.

MR: Okay.

EM: Thank you.

MR: Over and out.

EM: Beautiful.